When I announced my retirement a lot of people, including Athers, suggested I should have taken a sabbatical. Sports massage therapist Mark Saxby, a constant feature of my England career, and a valued source of personal support, came to me at the Oval and said: ‘I’ve got to ask you this. Why are you retiring? You’re only thirty-three years old. You’ve got your whole life, a whole world of cricket, ahead of you. You didn’t need to retire. You should have just taken the winter off.’

I did think about it, for about five minutes. But, as I told Mark, I was in a good place. This wasn’t a decision taken out of desperation, when I was deep in the bush. No one around me really needed the uncertainty of me marking time in what is often a horrible halfway house. You might not be there, in the dressing room or out in the middle, but the story will still be all about you.

When will he come back? Who will be under threat when he does so? How will his teammates feel? Was that fair, in my own mind? How would I feel as it all played out? Everyone might be looking at me as if I was mad to walk away, but was hanging on a realistic option? Was it really what I needed at this time in my life?

So many questions, but only one answer. I was done.

Obviously, I can’t say this with any great certainty, but on balance I don’t think six months off would have refreshed me. Knowing myself, and recognizing my inherent intransigence, I had reached a point of no return. Any selfishness on my part, because of some romantic notion that I would be transformed into a fresher, ageless version of me, would have been counter-productive.

I’d had my time. I didn’t want to be the elephant in the room. I didn’t want someone like Rory Burns to wonder if he was merely keeping my place warm. He has a position to secure, a career to forge. It is his turn to see if he can handle everything that comes with opening the batting for England.

Despite the speculation, no one came asking me to reconsider before this summer’s Ashes. In any case, I had moved on. Even taking the emotional power of memory into account, eight months or so on from that perfectly scripted farewell at the Oval, I am not missing playing for England.

Playing for England was all I ever wanted to do, and my life was structured around fulfilling that ambition. The transitional period is tricky, because one of my identities, that of international cricketer, has been taken